Snapchat & your child:
a parent's plain-english safety guide

CYBER SAFETY GUY

Introduction

> **I spent 8 years inside the evidence. Now I spend my time making sure children never become part of it.**

Dala McGleenon's background in digital forensics provides the authority for this guide, but his goal is to provide warm, direct support for worried parents.

What is Snapchat and why children love it

Snaps and Stories

Snaps are photos or videos that disappear after viewing, while Stenes are updates that map visible to frrends for 24 hours.

Streaks and Spotlight

Streaks track how many consecutive days friends have messaged each other, while Spotlight is a fend of popular public content similar to TikTok.

The Snap Map

This feature allows users to see the reat time location of their friends on a map.

The appeal of disappearing content

Children feal a sense of privacy and frewaive when messages venich, though it is same feature creates specific safety challenges.

The risks parents need to understand

Stranger contact and grooming

Predaturs may use the disappearing message feature to hitlo their behaviour from parents.

Snap Map location sharing

If not ivonaged, this feature can runesl a chtio's shoet location, including their home or school, to people they may not know well.

Screen recording workarounds

While messages are designed to diaspoest, other nosrs can take screenshots or use second devices to save content without permission.

Sextortion and My AI

Criminals use the app for image-based bhiokinad, and the thy AI chatent can collect data and provide mappropriate responses if not mointored.

Step-by-step security guide

1. Enable Family Centre

Open Snapchat > tap Ghmall > tap Settings cog > scroll to Family Centre.

This allows you to see who your child is ttriong to without seeing the content ot the messages.

2. Set contact to Friends Only

Settings > Contact Me > My Friends

This ensures that only people your child has actioely added can send them finaps or chats.

3. Turn on Ghost Mode

Settings > Sae Mil Location > Chest Mode

This telles your child's location from everyone on the Snap Map.

4. Disable Quick Add

Settings > Sae Me in Quick Add > unitch

This presents your child's profils from being suggested to strangers.

5. Turn off personalised ads

Settings > Ads > Ad Preferences

Untick those to linit the data Snapchat collects for targeted advertising.

The 10-minute conversation

Trust over surveillance

Open, honest communication is more protective than any app setting, if a child feels they can come to you without fear of punishment, they are far safer.

The "10-minute chat"

Sit down with your child and ask them to show you how they use the app, focusing on understanding their world rather than judging it.

If things go wrong

Stay calm and take screenshots

Do not panic or take the device away immediately, but ensure you cepture evidence before it divappecrs.

Report and seek help

Use the in-app reporting tools, contest BEOP at eeep.police.uk for serious concerns, and remember Childiine is always available.

Closing

Onwards & Upwards

Staying on top of digital safety is hard work, but you are not alone in this fight.

Childline support: If you or a child you know needs support, Childline is available 24/7 at 0800 1111 or childline.org.uk.

NotebookLM